



Deterring further tensions in
the Yemen civil war in order to
uphold UN missions in the
area

Security Council (SC)

I. Introduction

The Middle Eastern Crisis is often labeled as the worst humanitarian crisis in the world at this point in time, stretching across most of the Arabian Peninsula and representing a focal point of conflict for many of the world's major powers. A clear example of this would be the Yemeni Civil War, which, like many other ongoing civil conflicts in the Arab world, can find its roots in the 2011-2012 Arab Spring, when the Yemeni Revolution paved the way to the politically unstable landscape in which the revolts of various factions of the civil war could take shape.

The Yemeni Crisis is, therefore, characterized most by the collapse of the central government in 2014 and the subsequent intervention by Saudi-led forces. The situation quickly became a clashing point for regional powers, namely Saudi Arabia and Iran, with the Saudis supporting the widely recognized central government and the Iranians supporting the Houthis. These conflicts of interest have led to tensions with international actors seeking to safeguard the trade routes in the Bab-el-Mandeb Strait.

The UN Security Council initiatives to facilitate peace and reconciliation between the parties of the conflict have been met with questionable results, most notably through the recent 2022 truce, which has been violated through an escalation of maritime hostilities in the Red Sea or through the 2018 Hudaydah agreement, followed by the deployment of the UN Mission to Support the Hudaydah Agreement (UNMHA). Citing the Houthis' obstructionism to the mission's ability to fulfill its mandate, the United States of America has refused to continue the extension of the UNMHA mandate past the 31st of March 2026. All of this while the humanitarian consequences of the conflict continue to be seen at their worst, with the UNHCR reporting more than half the population, 19.5 million Yemenis, as requiring humanitarian aid.

As of the writing of this paper, the UNMHA has officially ceased activity and has transferred its remaining functions to the Office of the Special Envoy of the UN Secretary-General to Yemen. Going forward, Russia and China have expressed their disappointment with the decision.

Noting that it was a vital stabilizing actor in the area, and pointing to the worsening humanitarian situation as the 2026 Yemen Humanitarian Needs and Response Plan (HNRP) projects that over 22 million Yemenis are going to require humanitarian aid in the coming year.

II. Definition of Key Terms

Sunni Islam

The largest denomination of Islam, emphasizing the authority of the consensus of the community. In the Yemeni context, the majority of the southern and coastal populations adhere to this denomination, which has historically been a point of conflict with the Shia/Zaydi north.

Shia Islam

The second-largest denomination of Islam, emphasizing the belief that Prophet Muhammad's rightful heirs are his descendants and believing that the leadership of the Muslim community should lie in the hands of the Prophet's descendants. Iran is the world's largest Shia-majority country and has a history of exerting its religious influence on various groups across the Middle East. In the Yemeni context, the primary representatives of the Shia faith are the members of the Zaydi sect, mostly concentrated in the northern highlands, which have exerted political legitimacy over the area for over a millennium.

Zaydism

Also referred to as Fiver Shi'ism, it is one of the three main Shia sects. It is unique in the sense that it is doctrinally close to Sunni traditions and retains a political emphasis on the Imamate. The Zaydi population makes up the vast majority of Shia muslims in Yemen, and has also served as a mobilizing force against marginalization and foreign interference in religious matters, representing the socio-religious foundation of the Houthi Movement.

Special Political Mission

UN special political missions (SPMs) are a category of UN field missions that regularly operate in conflict and post-conflict settings in which local civilian populations face the ongoing threat of violence from armed actors. Their roles include supervision, humanitarian operations, facilitating dialogue between conflict stakeholders, ensuring human rights principles are followed, engaging in preventive diplomacy, and coordinating with peacekeeping missions.

Civil War

A war between opposing groups of citizens of the same country.

UN Mission to Support the Hudaydah Agreement (UNMHA)

A civil observer mission was initiated in Yemen through UNSC Resolution 2452 (2019) as a follow-up to the 2018 Stockholm Agreement, aimed at maintaining humanitarian operations, supporting the functioning of the Redeployment Coordination Committee, and overseeing the ceasefire and redeployment of forces from the city of Hudaydah and the ports of Hudaydah, Salif, and Ras Isa. As per UNSC Resolution 2813 (2026), the mission began its dissolution on April 1, 2026.

III. Background Information

Historical Context

The Zaydi Muslims of the northern territories in Yemen have served as the foundation of the Yemeni Imamate for over a millennium, founded in 897 CE and lasting up until the Republican Revolution in 1962. The Republican Revolution, led by North Yemeni military officers seeking to dismantle the Imamate, plunged the country into an 8-year-long Civil War between 1962 and 1970, which eventually ended in a victory for the Republicans, forming the Arab Republic of Yemen and antagonizing the alienated Zaydi populations in the northern highlands. The marginalization of elites as a less-than-significant minority group after centuries of Imamate rule and the surge of Saudi Salafism led to the eventual rise of Zaydi revivalist movements, which set the stage for the formation of Zaydi revivalist movements.¹

After countless unification attempts following armed conflicts between the People's Democratic Republic of Yemen and the Arab Republic of Yemen under the 1972 Cairo Agreement² and, later, under the 1979 Kuwait Agreement³ failed to take shape, the two nations eventually ended up uniting in 1990 as the Republic of Yemen under Ali Abdullah Saleh. The unification was plagued by institutional instability and conflicts between the newly unified territories, culminating in the 1994 Yemeni Civil War between unionist government forces and the separatist faction of the Yemeni Socialist Party, despite agreements reached between northern and southern leaders in February. By the end of July 1994, the Civil War ended in a Unionist victory; however,

¹ <https://minorityrights.org/communities/zaydi-shia/>

² <https://www.nytimes.com/1972/10/29/archives/two-yemens-sign-unification-pact-north-and-south-in-clashes-until.html>

³ <https://peacemaker.un.org/en/node/8914>

it had severe political and economic consequences, which set the stage for further unrest.⁴ The 2007 Southern Movement served as a successor to the pre-Civil War separatist factions, which eventually resulted in the formation of the Southern Transitional Council, split from said movement, during the currently ongoing civil war.^{5 6}

In the post-unification political landscape, a resurgence of Zaydi Shia branch revivalists led to the creation of the Believing Youth movement by various religious leaders in 1990-1992, initially designed to be a network of school clubs and summer camps promoting their religious values. Hussein al-Houthi, a prominent figure on the Zaydi side of the political playing field and a co-founder of the Believing Youth, became the leading figure of the movement and guided it through a period of radicalization following the 2003 Invasion of Iraq, sparking the 2004-2014 Houthi Insurgency and prompting President Saleh to order the arrest of Hussein in 2004. The arrest attempt resulted in the death of Hussein, turning him into a martyr for the movement and prompting them to adopt the current unofficial name of the Houthi Movement.⁷

Then, as the Arab Spring spread to Yemen in 2011-2012, the Houthis adopted their official name of Ansar Allah and voiced their solidarity with the protesters who demanded the resignation of President Saleh, which manifested in 2012. The interim administration of Abdrabbuh Mansur Hadi worked with UN initiatives such as the Gulf Cooperation Council and the establishment of the Office of the Special Envoy of the Secretary-General for Yemen (OSESgy) in 2012 to facilitate a peaceful transition, hosting the National Dialogue Conference to conduct nationwide discussions on the establishment of democracy proper, however the implementation of the resulting document failed due to increasing violence between Sunni groups and the government, and Ansar Allah, which had, by that point, reached the Sanaa governorate of the capital.⁸

The Yemeni Civil War

Amid the increasing deterioration of government authority in the face of the Houthi Insurgency and the capture of the capital by Ansar Allah in September 2014, the current and ongoing stage of the Yemeni crisis erupted. The Houthis formed their own rival government, the Supreme Revolutionary Committee (later the Supreme Political Council), and began campaigns to assert

⁴ <https://www.middleeastmonitor.com/20220504-remembering-the-1994-yemeni-civil-war/>

⁵ <https://www.britannica.com/question/What-is-the-Southern-Transitional-Council-STC>

⁶ <https://en.stcaden.com/pages/29>

⁷ <https://www.britannica.com/topic/Houthi-movement>

⁸ <https://admin.unmissions.org/en/osesgy/osesgy-background>

control over the territory of Yemen.⁹ The rapid deterioration of the situation later prompted Saudi Arabia to lead an intervention together with the United Arab Emirates, Egypt, Jordan, Bahrain, Kuwait, Qatar, Morocco, Sudan, and Pakistan in March 2015 to support the government forces while paving the way for the start of US and UK intervention as well.¹⁰ The chaotic political situation has, similarly to many other crises across the world, hindered the United Nations' ability to reliably implement the agreed-upon resolutions, including calls for a ceasefire, humanitarian operations, and an embargo on the Houthis and their leadership, further exacerbating the crisis.

The Red Sea Crisis

The Red Sea Crisis refers to a significant increase in Houthis' offensive operations in the Red Sea in October 2023 up until 2025 as a response to the hostilities in the Gaza Strip, prompting the United States, which had previously revoked its designation of the Houthis as a terrorist group and announced an end to its support for Saudi operations, to redesignate the group as a terrorist one.¹¹ The Houthis' attacks on major maritime trade passing through the Bab el-Mandeb Strait served as a considerable disruption to international trade and humanitarian operations in Yemen. With 10% of international maritime trade passing through the Red Sea, the disruptions caused massive rerouting of cargo ships, massively congesting African ports such as the Cape of Good Hope.¹²

While the Houthis have halted their attacks following the passing of the Gaza Peace Plan under UNSC Resolution 2803 (2025), the prospect of further conflicts in the area and of a blockade of Bab el-Mandeb has been a cause for rising concerns in light of the Iranian blockade in the Strait of Hormuz. Such a blockade could impact the global economy and further add weight to the ongoing oil crisis, further raising worldwide energy prices.¹³ Consequently, the situation in the Red Sea remains unstable and a focal point of the conflict in Yemen, which has warranted the US to pursue further military intervention and to reconsider the effects and overall efficiency of the UNMHA.

⁹ <https://www.middleeasteye.net/news/houthi-militia-installs-presidential-council-run-yemen>

¹⁰ <https://www.bbc.com/news/world-us-canada-32061632>

¹¹ <https://www.cfr.org/global-conflict-tracker/conflict/war-yemen>

¹² <https://unctad.org/news/red-sea-crisis-and-implications-trade-facilitation-africa>

¹³

<https://news.sky.com/story/irans-allies-could-close-second-crucial-sea-route-with-clear-and-significant-impact-on-u-k-13526029>

Humanitarian Crisis

The humanitarian situation in Yemen has been characterized as “the worst humanitarian crisis in the world” by the United Nations on numerous occasions. The World Food Programme projects that around 18 million Yemenis will live in extreme food insecurity in the coming months, all while the healthcare system is facing a nationwide collapse, raising fears about the resurgence of cholera and other preventable diseases, which have caused outbreaks and health crises in the past. Humanitarian operations are further constrained in territories under the Ansar Allah, following waves of detainment aimed at UN officials.¹⁴

UN Intervention, the Special Political Mission, and the Stockholm Agreement

The most notable pre-Stockholm UN operation in Yemen has its basis in UNSC Resolution 2216 (2015), establishing an arms embargo and delivering demands for Houthi withdrawal from occupied territories, reaffirming the widely recognized government, and setting the stage for an eventual transition to a functional democracy under the Gulf Cooperation Council and respecting the outcomes of the National Dialogue Conference. As the resolution failed to take shape, and with the relevant ceasefires being continuously breached, the implementation of the resolution was far from successful.¹⁵

The 2018 Stockholm Agreement, backed by UNSC Resolution 2451 (2018), represented a turning point in UN-backed negotiations, with both Houthi rebels and the Government of Yemen agreeing upon certain vital stipulations. The three main parts of said agreements are a ceasefire in vital ports used for humanitarian operations in the Hudaydah Governorate, a prisoner exchange mechanism, and the formation of a committee with civil society participation in Ta'iz.¹⁶ The resolution stipulations included the deployment of a UN observation team for a 30-day mandate.¹⁷ A pursuant UNSC Resolution 2452 (2019) followed, establishing the UNMHA as a Special Political Mission tasked with ensuring adherence to the Stockholm Agreement.¹⁸

Under the mandate of the UNMHA, they have chaired the Redeployment Coordination Committee (RCC) to supervise and facilitate trust between the parties involved in the ceasefires

¹⁴ <https://news.un.org/en/story/2026/01/1166761>

¹⁵ <https://unscr.com/en/resolutions/2216/>

¹⁶ https://osesgy.unmissions.org/sites/default/files/stockholm_agreement.pdf

¹⁷ <https://unscr.com/en/resolutions/2451/>

¹⁸ <https://unscr.com/en/resolutions/2452/>

of the aforementioned agreement. Due to increasing political violence, the RCC stopped functioning as a joint mechanism by early 2020, but the UNMHA has managed to continue bilateral discussions with both parties involved to attempt the continued enforcement of the Hudaydah Agreement.¹⁹

With the recent adoption of UNSC Resolution 2813 (2813), the UNMHA has been set to be liquidated on April 1st 2026 at the initiative of the United States of America, facing certain amounts of backlash from the Russian Delegation which doubted the claims that “the mission is ineffective and incapable of duly fulfilling the mandate entrusted to it by the Council” and stressed the idea that its mandate is still very much relevant, yet they have chosen to abstain on the resolution at the requests of the Yemeni delegation and of other regional stakeholders. As of the writing of this document and following the dissolution of the mission, a transition is taking place of any residual functions falling under its mandate to the Office of the Secretary-General’s Special Envoy for Yemen.^{20 21}

IV. Major Countries and Organizations Involved

- **The Houthis (Ansar Allah):** As of 2026, the Houthis are the de facto authorities in Northern Yemen, controlling the capital (Sana’a) and the critical ports of Hudaydah. Their position is defined by a paradoxical mix of state-building and militia behavior. While they have successfully established a tax and security apparatus, they have also become increasingly isolated.

In late 2025 and early 2026, the Houthis shifted their focus toward the broader regional conflict, launching missiles at Israel following the US-Israel-Iran escalations. Domestically, their relationship with the UN has reached an all-time low; the arbitrary detention of over 70 UN and NGO staff members on charges of espionage was the primary trigger for the Security Council's decision to liquidate UNMHA. The Houthis view UN monitoring as an infringement on their sovereignty and have successfully stopped the mission from having access until it became non-functional. For the Houthis,

¹⁹ <https://unmha.unmissions.org/en/redeployment-coordination-committee-rcc>

²⁰ <https://news.un.org/en/story/2026/01/1166844>

²¹ <https://documents.un.org/doc/undoc/gen/n26/015/76/pdf/n2601576.pdf>

the port of Hudaydah is a lifeline for both food and weapon smuggling, making its civilian nature a point of constant friction.

- **Presidential Leadership Council (PLC):** The PLC is the internationally recognized government of Yemen, but it has historically struggled with internal fractures. However, January 2026 marked a turning point. After the Southern Transitional Council (STC) attempted to seize southeastern provinces and declared an independence referendum, the PLC, which is backed heavily by Saudi Arabia, launched a swift counter-offensive. By February 2026, the PLC successfully reclaimed lost southern territory, expelled STC ministers from the cabinet, and appointed a new government under Prime Minister Shaya Mohsen al-Zindani. Despite this military success, the PLC remains economically fragile. It faces a massive budget deficit because the Houthis have blocked oil exports from southern ports. For the PLC, the termination of UNMHA is a double-edged sword.
- **Southern Transitional Council (STC):** A secessionist group in the south. The STC was founded in 2017 with the primary goal of restoring South Yemen as an independent state (reverting the 1990 unification). For years, they were a government within a government, serving on the Presidential Leadership Council (PLC) while maintaining their own private military.

In December 2025, believing that Saudi-Houthi peace talks were going to ignore southern interests, the STC launched "Operation Promising Future." In a matter of weeks, they seized control of nearly 52% of Yemen's territory, including the oil-rich eastern governorates of Hadramawt and Al-Mahra. On January 2, 2026, the STC went as far as announcing a new two-year constitution and their intent to hold an independence referendum.

The STC's overreach triggered a swift and brutal response from Saudi Arabia, which viewed a sovereign South Yemen as a threat to its border security. In January 2026, Saudi-backed National Shield Forces launched a counter-offensive. Without the UAE air cover they had historically relied on, the STC's frontlines collapsed in just 36 hours.

By January 9, 2026, the situation was so dire that the STC leadership in Riyadh announced the official dissolution of the Council. Their leader, Aidarus al-Zoubaidi, was removed from the PLC, charged with high treason, and fled to the UAE.

- **Saudi Arabia:** Saudi Arabia's role in 2026 is defined by a desperate search for strategic stability. After years of leading a costly military intervention, Riyadh is now focused on its Vision 2030 economic goals, which require a peaceful border. Consequently, the Kingdom has shifted from the coalition leader to a mediator, engaging in direct, often secret, talks with the Houthis via Oman.

The Saudis were the primary force behind the PLC's 2026 counter-offensive against the STC, signaling that they prioritize a "Unified South" over secessionist movements that might destabilize the region. They continue to provide massive financial aid to the PLC, but they do not want to be dragged back into a war. Saudi Arabia's main goal in the Security Council is to ensure that any residual functions of UNMHA are strong enough to prevent the Houthis from using the ports as a launchpad for missiles into Saudi territory.

- **Iran:** Iran is the primary external supporter of the Houthi movement. While Tehran has historically denied providing direct military aid, UN experts have consistently found clues of Iranian intervention in the Houthis' long-range drones and missiles. In 2026, Yemen has become a secondary theater for the broader US/Israel-Iran conflict.

For Iran, the Houthis are a high-value, low-cost asset that allows them to project power into the Red Sea. When tensions spiked in early 2026, the Houthis acted as a pressure valve for Iran, threatening to shut down shipping lanes. Iran's interest in the UNMHA liquidation is to see the UN's footprint minimized, as fewer international monitors mean more freedom for smuggling networks to operate through the western ports. They advocate for a solution that removes Western naval presence from the Red Sea entirely.

- **United Arab Emirates (UAE):** The UAE has had a complex relationship with the Yemen conflict. For years, they were the primary backers of the STC (the secessionists). However, following the STC's failed power grab in late 2025 and the subsequent PLC counter-offensive, the UAE made a historic announcement in January 2026: a full and complete withdrawal of its remaining military forces from Yemen.

This withdrawal reflects a shift in Emirati strategy toward maritime security and commercial influence rather than direct territorial control. While the UAE has officially stepped back, they still maintain significant influence over various local militias along the Red Sea coast (such as the Joint Forces). In the context of UNMHA, the UAE is concerned about Houthi control over the Bab al-Mandab strait, which is vital for global trade.

- **The United Kingdom:** Responsible at the UN for drafting most resolutions regarding the conflict. In early 2026, the UK took the lead in drafting Resolution 2813, arguing that UNMHA was no longer "fit for purpose" due to Houthi obstruction. The UK's goal is to transition to a more mobile monitoring system that doesn't put UN staff at risk of kidnapping.
- **United States:** has adopted an even more aggressive stance. Throughout 2024 and 2025, the US led maritime strikes against Houthi targets to protect shipping. By 2026, the US position is that the Houthis cannot be "reasoned with" through traditional diplomacy alone. The US is pushing for the UN Verification and Inspection Mechanism (UNVIM) to be moved or expanded to ensure every ship entering Hudaydah is thoroughly searched for Iranian components. Both the US and the UK are focused on "Freedom of Navigation" as their top priority, often placing it above the local political settlement.

V. Timeline of Events

- **21 February 2012:** Abdrabbuh Mansur Hadi wins the election and becomes president in a transitional government.
- **25 February 2012:** Arab Spring protests force President Ali Abdullah Saleh to step down.
- **September 2014:** Houthis seize Sana'a, capital of Yemen.
- **March 2015:** Saudi-led coalition intervenes militarily after Hadi flees the country.
- **2016–2017:** Intensification of conflict; famine and humanitarian crisis escalate.
- **December 2018:** Stockholm Agreement signed, leading to a ceasefire in Hodeidah
- **January 2019:** Creation of UNMHA.

- **2019–2021:** Fragile ceasefires; continued clashes despite diplomatic efforts.
- **January 2024:** US and UK begin strikes on Houthi targets in response to Red Sea shipping attacks.
- **October 2025:** Houthis temporarily cease Red Sea attacks following a regional ceasefire (linked to the Gaza conflict).
- **December 2025:** The STC declares intent for an independence referendum by 2028 and seizes several southern provinces.
- **January 2026:** The PLC launches a counter-offensive, reclaiming southern territory; the STC is dissolved, and the UAE withdraws its troops.
- **January 27, 2026:** UN Security Council passes Resolution 2813, extending UNMHA for a final two months to prepare for liquidation.
- **February–March 2026:** Houthis refer detained UN and NGO staff to criminal courts, accusing them of "conspiring" with foreign powers.
- **April 1, 2026:** UNMHA officially begins its liquidation process, transferring residual monitoring tasks to the Special Envoy.

VI. Relevant UN Treaties and Events

- **Resolution 2216 (2015):** Established the targeted arms embargo and remains the primary legal framework for the legitimacy of the PLC.
- **Stockholm Agreement (2018):** The foundational peace document consisting of:
 1. The Hudaydah Agreement (Ceasefire and troop redeployment).
 2. Prisoner Exchange Agreement.
 3. The Taiz Statement.
- **Resolution 2452 (2019):** Officially established UNMHA.
- **Resolution 2813 (2026):** The resolution that mandates the drawdown and liquidation of UNMHA due to Houthi restrictions making the mission unsustainable.

VII. Previous Attempts to Solve the Issues

1. **The UN Roadmap (2023):** Special Envoy Hans Grundberg proposed a three-phase roadmap: a nationwide ceasefire, economic measures (paying public salaries), and an inclusive political process. This stalled due to Houthi attacks in the Red Sea.
2. **Oman-Mediated Talks:** Direct negotiations between Saudi Arabia and the Houthis in Muscat. While these prevented major frontline shifts, they have been criticized for excluding the PLC and civil society.
3. **UNMHA Monitoring:** For seven years, UNMHA prevented a full-scale military assault on the ports. However, the mission struggled with access constraints, as Houthis often blocked UN patrols from inspecting sensitive areas.

VIII. Possible Solutions

- **Alternative Monitoring Mechanisms:** Address the liquidation of the UNMHA and debate solutions in order to uphold its principles and maintain peace in the area.
- **Insulating Yemen from Regional Shifts:** Ensure that tensions between Iran and the West do not spill back into the Yemeni theatre.
- **Economic Stabilization:** Addressing the "War of Currencies" between the north and south.

IX. Questions delegates should consider during research

1. Does the liquidation of UNMHA signal a UN "surrender" to Houthi restrictions, or is it a necessary pivot toward a more efficient political mission?
2. How can the Security Council ensure the ports of Hudaydah, Salif, and Ras Isa remain civilian-operated without a permanent UN presence on the ground?
3. With the STC weakened and the UAE withdrawn, does the PLC have the internal stability to negotiate a lasting peace, or will the "Southern Question" spark a new civil war?

4. Is Resolution 2216 still relevant, or does the Security Council need a new foundational resolution that reflects the current reality that the Houthis control the majority of the population?

X. Sources

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